# Chandrashekhara Acharya

*Чандрашекхара Ачарья (Ачарьяратна) · @chandrashekhara-acharya*

## Acharyaratna

His name was Sri Chandrashekhara Acharya, and the Vaishnavas also knew him by the title Acharyaratna, “the jewel among acharyas”: so he is called both in the “Charitamrita” and in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” which speaks of “the house of Sri Acharyaratna” (Madhya 18.226). Elsewhere Vrindavana Dasa honours him as “Sri Chandrashekhara-deva” (CB, Adi 2.34). In the Lord's pastimes he was His relative — His meso, the husband of His mother's sister — and Mahaprabhu, speaking of him, affectionately called him “My mesomashai.”

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, listing the branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree, gives him the place of a great branch:

“Acharyaratna is another great branch, and his associates are the twigs upon it.” (CC, Adi 10.12)

“Acharyaratna was also known as Sri Chandrashekhara. In his house Sri Chaitanya played the role of the goddess Adi-shakti in a drama.” (CC, Adi 10.13)

With this single verse the “Charitamrita” marked what Chandrashekhara's house has remained forever in the memory of the devotees: here the Lord revealed Himself in the form of His own primordial energy. Of this pastime we shall speak below.

Like all the Lord's elders, he came into the world before Him. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says:

“By the order of Lord Chaitanya many of His eternal associates, such as Sri Chandrashekhara, Jagadisha, Gopinatha Acharya, Shriman Pandita, Murari Gupta, Sri Garuda Pandita and Gangadasa Pandita, were born secretly in Nadia before His coming.” (CB, Adi 2.98–99)

And the “Charitamrita,” listing those whom Krishna sent to the earth ahead of Himself, names him too:

“First He sent to the Earth all His intimates and elders. I shall list them briefly — to describe them all in detail is simply impossible.” (CC, Adi 13.53)

“Sri Shachi Devi and Jagannatha Mishra, Sri Madhavendra Puri, Keshava Bharati, Ishvara Puri, Advaita Acharya, Srivasa Pandita, Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi and Thakura Haridasa.” (CC, Adi 13.54–55)

One of the biographies explains that all of Mahaprabhu's elders descend to the earth before He Himself is born[1].

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” reveals who he was before:

“The wise should know Acharya Chandrashekhara as Chandra (the Moon); Shriman Uddhava Dasa is also an avesha-avatara of the Moon.” (GGD 112)

There too, speaking of the nine nidhis — treasures who were born as the Lord's favourites with the titles “nidhi,” “ratna” and “garbha” — Karnapura names “Shriman Acharyaratna” among them (GGD 102–103). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, following him, writes that Chandrashekhara is one of the nine nidhis, or Chandra[2].

Yadunatha Dasa, a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami, in the “Shakha-nirnayamrita” praises him, according to one of the biographies, as a vessel of Paurnamasi's great love and a full moon of boundless compassion.

Murari Gupta, his contemporary, also links him with the Moon — and names his teachers:

“The disciple of them both became the divine Chandrashekhara, a portion of the Moon; greatly renowned, he is celebrated on earth as Acharyaratna.” (Murari, 1.4.6)

“Both” here are Sri Madhavendra Puri (in Murari, Madhava Puri) and Advaita Acharya, of whom Murari speaks in the preceding verse. Elsewhere he recalls “the teacher Chandrashekhara, king of the twice-born”: at the name of Krishna the hairs on his body stood on end, and tears streamed down his face (Murari, 1.1.21).

## Shrihatta and the Lord's Family

Chandrashekhara's birthplace was Shrihatta (Sylhet) — so, according to one of the biographies, Yadunatha Dasa also says. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” sings of the same: Srivasa Pandita, Srirama Pandita and Sri Chandrashekhara-deva, honoured by the three worlds, and with them Murari, the physician of the disease of worldly existence — all these Vaishnavas appeared in Shrihatta (CB, Adi 2.34–35)[3]. Later he lived in Navadvipa.

His wife was Sarvajaya Devi, Shachi's sister — so it is established in the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana.” Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura in the “Amrita-pravaha-bhashya” is more cautious: according to some accounts, he writes, Acharyaratna was Chaitanya's meso. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta calls him “the Lord's devotee meso.”

Even before the Lord's advent, when Advaita Acharya returned to Bengal and became the head of the local Vaishnavas, Srivasa, Chandrashekhara, Gangadasa and others gathered around Him.

According to one of the biographies, Chandrashekhara lived in Mayapur as a neighbour of Jagannatha Mishra — where the Sri Chaitanya Math founded by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati now stands. Together with his wife he constantly visited Mishra's house: they helped run the household and cared for the family's welfare, and when Nimai was born, they came to see Him and look after Him[4].

On the day of the Lord's birth Chandrashekhara's wife came to Shachi together with Malini, Srivasa's wife:

“Malini, the wife of Srivasa Thakura, came with Chandrashekhara's wife and many other women. With great joy they honoured the infant, offering Him vermilion, turmeric, oil, puffed rice, coconuts, bananas and other fruits.” (CC, Adi 13.110)

The women performed all the auspicious rites that are due at a child's birth.

When Jagannatha Mishra entered the eternal pastimes, Chandrashekhara took upon himself the care of Shachi's house: from then on the whole household of the widow rested on him.

## Gaya and the Night Kirtans

According to one of the biographies, Chandrashekhara was with the Lord in Gaya as well. When the Lord fell in ecstasy before the footprints of Vishnu and at that very moment Ishvara Puri approached Him, Chandrashekhara was nearby, and he was told what had happened[5].

Returning from Gaya, Mahaprabhu began the sankirtana. The place of the night kirtan was Srivasa's house, but not only that:

“Every night the devotees sang kirtan in the house of Srivasa, or sometimes in the house of Chandrashekhara.” (CB, Madhya 8.111)

These nights at Srivasa's and at Chandrashekhara's are recalled also in the accounts of Haridasa, Jagadananda, Vakreshvara, Buddhimanta Khan, Jagadisha and Sadashiva: all of them sang and danced in both houses.

Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” and Murari Gupta tell how once the Lord, seized by the bhava of Balarama, told Gadadhara to call His Vaishnava friends, and they came, led by Acharyaratna.

Seeing the Lord so shaken, Acharyaratna asked tenderly: “Tell us Yourself, my boy, what is the cause?” — and the Lord related that He had seen beside Him Halayudha, like a white mountain; so in Lochana Dasa, while in Murari (2.14.11–13) all who came ask this question. Then in the form of Halayudha the Lord danced with all the devotees, and in the morning they bathed together in the Ganga. The “Charitamrita” also recalls that when the Lord walked about, enraptured, imitating Baladeva, Chandrashekhara saw in Him Sri Balarama Himself (CC, Adi 17.118).

He was also among the few who saw how the Lord accepted Jagai and Madhai. These two, born in a pure brahmana family, had abandoned its dignity and lived by robbery; but by the Lord's mercy a new life began for them: He forgave them and admitted them to the kirtan. The Vaishnavas accepted them as their own and brought them into Gaurasundara's house; only the closest associates and the two former robbers went in, and the doors were locked behind them. Chandrashekhara Acharya was among the witnesses of these wondrous deeds. Vrindavana Dasa, listing those who sat around the Lord then — Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Haridasa, Garuda, Ramai, Srivasa, Gangadasa — concludes: Vakreshvara Pandita and Chandrashekhara Acharya — all of them know all the deeds of Chaitanya (CB, Madhya 13.239–240).

## The Drama of Vraja

The most famous event connected with his name took place in his home. Here Mahaprabhu, for the first time in Bengal, sang and danced in the mood of the Goddess, devi-bhava — so writes Srila Bhaktisiddhanta. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 18) describes this pastime in detail, Murari Gupta and Lochana Dasa sing of it, and the “Charitamrita” recalls it in two verses:

“Then in the house of Sri Chandrashekhara Sri Chaitanya played the role of Rukmini in a drama devoted to Krishna's pastimes.” (CC, Adi 17.241)

“At times Sri Chaitanya played the roles of the goddess Durga, Lakshmi or Yogamaya. Seated on the couch of Vishnu, He bestowed on all the devotees divine love for Sri Krishna.” (CC, Adi 17.242)

It began when the Lord revealed to the devotees His wish to present the pastimes of Vraja. He called Sadashiva Pandita and Buddhimanta Khan and told them to prepare the costumes, indicating who was to wear what (CB, Madhya 18.7). Buddhimanta Khan carried it all out and dressed the Lord himself, and the Lord, pleased with his service, was especially merciful to him[6].

Seeing the costumes, the Lord announced that He would dance in the form of Lakshmi, but that only one who had conquered the senses had the right to watch the dance. Advaita and Srivasa grew sad: “We have not conquered the senses,” they said, “so we may not go there.” The Lord smiled slightly: “If you do not come, for whom shall I dance?” — and reassured everyone: “Today you will all become great masters of yoga, and looking at Me no one will fall into delusion” (CB, Madhya 18.17–26). To see the Lord in a feminine form is given only to those who are free from worldly perception — and with this freedom He graced all who had gathered, by His mercy[7].

Shachi too came with Vishnupriya to see the Lord dance in the form of Lakshmi, and the Vaishnavas brought their families. Gangadasa Pandita was also among the spectators: during the drama he talked with Brahmananda. Advaita became the great jester, maha-vidushaka; Haridasa Thakura the kotal, the town watchman; Srivasa Narada, and Ramai Pandita his disciple. Mukunda began to sing of Krishna, and the drama started: Haridasa the kotal, twirling his staff, called on everyone to watch attentively. Playing their roles, the devotees revealed their own eternal nature and the truth about Gaura.

Srivasa as Narada told how he had travelled through countless universes, longing to see Krishna, had come to Vaikuntha and found it deserted; and hearing that Krishna had come to Nadia, he had come to Navadvipa to see how the Lord dances in the form of Lakshmi. Srivasa's mood was so extraordinary that

Shachi fainted, and the women brought her round by repeating Krishna's name.

Then Vishvambhara came out in the form of Rukmini. Absorbed in her mood, He thought Himself the daughter of the king of Vidarbha, tearfully read to Krishna Rukmini's letter — seven verses of the "Bhagavatam" — and wrote it on the ground: the ink was His tears, and the pen His finger (CB, Madhya 18.72–73)[8]. The Vaishnavas sank in the bliss of love.

In the second prahara Gadadhara Pandita Gosvami came out — in the dress of a maiden of Vraja, his heart overflowing with prema — and danced in the form of Rama, the goddess Lakshmi; according to one of the biographies, he appeared as a gopi and danced, overwhelmed by her love. At last Mahaprabhu appeared in the form of Adya-shakti, the primordial energy, and Nityananda as Badai Buri, Radharani's grandmother on her mother's side. Seeing the Lord's dance in the form of Adya-shakti, Nityananda lost consciousness, and the devotees wept aloud.

Each saw the Lord according to his own mood: some as Kamala, others as Lakshmi, Sita or Mahamaya[9]. Even those who had known Him from birth did not recognize Him; even Shachi did not. Under the guise of a drama the Lord manifested all His energies and taught everyone to give each of them its due honour, granting also the power to do so. It was not play-acting but the pastime of the Lord Himself, the source of all energies: the form of His shakti does not make Him subject to maya, and by this pastime He bestowed prema on those assembled.

Then the Lord took the Deity of Gopinatha on His lap and sat on the couch in the mood of Mahalakshmi, and the devotees began to offer Him hymns of praise.

Suddenly night gave way to dawn, and the devotees grieved that the spectacle was over. Seeing their sorrow, the Lord in the mood of Jagajjanani, the Mother of the universe, full of tenderness, took each one on His lap and nursed them, and their grief left them (CB, Madhya 18.225)[10].

By the Lord's power a wondrous effulgence remained in Chandrashekhara's house for seven days:

"Thus in the house of Sri Acharyaratna a wonderful effulgence was manifest for seven days." (CB, Madhya 18.226)

It seemed as if the moon, the sun and lightning were blazing at once. Whoever came to the Acharya's house could not open his eyes, and people asked why; but the Vaishnavas only smiled to themselves and explained nothing (CB, Madhya 18.227–230). Lochana Dasa writes that from the Lord's effulgence in Chandrashekhara's house it was as if hundreds of thousands of moons had risen.

## Vrajapattana

Chandrashekhara's house came to be called Vrajapattana, "the town of Vraja": here, as Srila Bhaktisiddhanta writes, the Lord staged the drama of Vrindavana.

To Bhaktisiddhanta himself this place was especially dear. In 1909 he built a hut here, "Vraja-pattan," and lived in it, continuing his vow — to chant a billion holy names — while in his heart dwelling on the bank of Radha-kunda. And in 1918, on Gaura-purnima, the very day he accepted tridandi-sannyasa, Bhaktisiddhanta installed Deities in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya and founded the Sri Chaitanya Math, the chief centre of the Gaudiya Maths; he did this fulfilling the wish of Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura[11].

Today on this very spot stands the great octagonal temple of the Sri Chaitanya Math — the principal math, the support of the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha, the world assembly of Vaishnavas; in it the Deities of the acharyas of the four genuine sampradayas are also worshipped.

## The Procession to the Kazi

Chandrashekhara was with the Lord also on the night when the nagara-sankirtana procession moved to the house of Chand Kazi and humbled him. With that procession Mahaprabhu began the distribution throughout the world of the most confidential treasure of Gokula — nama-sankirtana.

## The Lord's Sannyasa

Chandrashekhara learned in advance, from Nityananda, that the Lord intended to accept sannyasa. Mahaprabhu Himself named the few to whom this could be revealed:

“I shall accept sannyasa from him. Only to five may You tell of this: to My mother, Gadadhara, Brahmananda Bharati, Chandrashekhara Acharya and Mukunda.” (CB, Madhya 28.11–12)

The Lord left Navadvipa before dawn. When in the morning the devotees came to His house and did not find Him, Chandrashekhara was among those who wept in the courtyard (CB, Madhya 28.85). As Lochana Dasa relates in the “Chaitanya-mangala,” the devotees sent the chief among them after the Lord — Chandrashekhara Acharya, Damodara Pandita, Vakreshvara and others — and Nityananda went with them. In Katwa, according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” all whom the Lord had called beforehand gradually gathered: Nityananda, Gadadhara, Mukunda, Chandrashekhara Acharya and Brahmananda (CB, Madhya 28.103–104).

The Lord Himself needed no rites at all: sannyasa was His pastime, and all that it required He entrusted to Chandrashekhara. In the morning the Master of all the worlds told him: “All the rites that the rules require — you perform them: you I have made My representative,” — and Chandrashekhara Acharya, at the Lord's word, carried out all that was prescribed (CB, Madhya 28.132–134). The “Charitamrita” says the same:

“The Lord was accompanied by Nityananda Prabhu, Chandrashekhara Acharya and Mukunda Datta. They performed all the necessary rites.” (CC, Adi 17.273)

Thus together with Nityananda and Mukunda Datta he performed according to the shastras all that befitted the pastime of sannyasa; Murari Gupta adds that “the venerable Acharyaratna, knower of the injunctions, performed the worship of Krishna according to the rules” (Murari, 3.2.6).

Then Chandrashekhara returned to Navadvipa and told everyone of the Lord's sannyasa. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” the Lord Himself let him go: at dawn, leaving for the forest, He embraced Chandrashekhara and wept aloud:

“Go back home and tell all the Vaishnavas that I have gone to the forest. Go home and do not grieve. I cannot leave your heart. You are My father, and I am your son. You are My beloved companion birth after birth.” (CB, Antya 1.27–29)

Chandrashekhara fell unconscious, and when he came to himself he went to Navadvipa and told everyone: “The Lord has gone to the forest” (CB, Antya 1.30–34). One of the biographies adds that, sending His mesomashai to Navadvipa-Mayapur, Mahaprabhu charged him to console everyone while He was away, and that Chandrashekhara had followed the Lord at a distance and seen everything with his own eyes. According to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” the Lord let him go after three days: “We shall see each other again, soon we shall meet — do not grieve,” — and Chandrashekhara left in tears; he brought the news to Shachi and Vishnupriya, and both wept bitterly. Murari Gupta writes that on the seventh day Chandrashekhara came to the dejected devotees and, in a voice broken with tears, told them everything — and it is from his words that Murari relates the Lord's sannyasa and His frenzy in the land of Radha (Murari, 3.1.8–9; 3.3).

The “Charitamrita” tells of these days differently[12]. After His sannyasa the Lord in ecstasy rushed towards Vrindavana, but Nityananda by a stratagem led Him to the Ganga near Shantipura, and sent

Chandrashekhara ahead:

“At that time Sri Nityananda ordered Chandrashekhara: ‘Go quickly to the house of Advaita Acharya. I shall bring Sri Chaitanya to Advaita's house. But let Advaita wait for us with a boat on the bank of the Ganga. Then go to Navadvipa for Mother Shachi and all the devotees.’” (CC, Madhya 3.20–22)

Thus through Chandrashekhara the news of the Lord's sannyasa reached the devotees of Shantipura and Navadvipa.

At Nityananda's word he brought Shachi from Navadvipa to Advaita's house in a palanquin, and the devotees of Navadvipa came with them:

“The next morning after Mahaprabhu's arrival Chandrashekhara brought Mother Shachi in a palanquin. Many other devotees also came with them.” (CC, Madhya 3.137)

## The Puri Years

The Lord settled in Puri and went travelling through the South. When He returned, the news was sent to Gauda with Kala Krishnadasa — that very servant whom the Lord had rescued in the South from the snares of the Bhattathari women[13]. In Bengal Kala Krishnadasa met Chandrashekhara too, and Acharyaratna, together with the other devotees, rejoiced on hearing the news (CC, Madhya 10.81–84).

From then on, together with the devotees of Gauda, he went to Purushottama-dhama for the chaturmasya and spent those months there with the Lord. His name stands both in the lists of those who went with Advaita (Murari, 4.17.3) and among those who set out in the third year (CC, Madhya 16.16). In Puri he was Mahaprabhu's companion in many pastimes — at the cleansing of the Gundicha temple, in the water pastimes in Narendra-sarovara and others.

In a conversation with Vallabha Bhatta the Lord, speaking of the Vaishnavas born in the land of Bengal, named Acharyaratna first, and after him Acharyanidhi, Gadadhara Pandita, Jagadananda, Damodara, Shankara, Vakreshvara, Kashishvara, Mukunda, Vasudeva, Murari and many others (CC, Antya 7.48–49) — and added:

“All of them everywhere preach the glory of chanting the holy names of God and the enchanting beauty of love for Krishna. Thanks to all of them I have understood the essence of pure devotion to Krishna.” (CC, Antya 7.50)

In Bengal Chandrashekhara was also present, according to one of the biographies, at Nityananda's wedding in Badagachhi: there Srivasa, Advaita, Sri Chandrashekhara, Murari Gupta and other devotees of Gaurasundara gathered and sang sankirtana.

When and where he left this world, the sources do not say. No biography gives the day of his appearance or of his departure, and they are not in our calendar either.

## Significance

The sources describe Chandrashekhara Acharya's life in a few strokes, but precise ones. He is an eternal associate, sent into the world before the Lord, a great branch of Chaitanya's tree; in the pastime, a relative on whose shoulders fell the care of Shachi's house. His house the Lord chose for the night kirtans and for the drama of Vraja, in which He revealed Himself in the form of His energies and gave prema to all. To him, the witness of all the Lord's confidential deeds in Navadvipa, Mahaprabhu entrusted the news of His sannyasa and made him His representative in its rites. And he kept his faithfulness to the end, coming to the Lord in Puri year after year.

The biographies of the Lord's associates invariably count him among their heroes. The site of his house, Vrajapattana, became the heart of the Sri Chaitanya Math, from which Srila Bhaktisiddhanta led the

preaching of nama-sankirtana throughout the world — the sankirtana whose beginning the Lord had laid in Navadvipa.

**1.** In one place this biography refers to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” Adi 9.98–99; read Adi 2.98–99.

**2.** One of the biographies calls him an incarnation of the moon-god. The identification follows the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika”; Chandrashekhara himself is an eternal associate of the Lord (nitya-siddha) who descended by His will (CB, Adi 2.98), not a demigod born by the force of karma. Murari Gupta too calls him “a portion of the Moon” (1.4.6).

**3.** One of the biographies gives the reference Adi 1.34–36; read Adi 2.34–35.

**4.** According to one of the biographies, they visited Mishra's house and helped with the household even before the Lord's advent; according to another, they began to come after His advent, to see Him and care for Him.

**5.** The other biographies do not speak of his journey to Gaya. That the Lord set out for Gaya together with Chandrashekhara Acharya is also told in Kavi Karnapura's “Chaitanya-charita-mahakavya.”

**6.** One of the biographies supports the account of the costumes with references to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (12), but its verse numbers in different places differ by almost a thousand.

**7.** “Masters of yoga” here are not those who have reached the goal by yogic effort: the Lord by His mercy freed everyone from the worldly view, so that they would see His pastime in a feminine form as it is — spiritual and alien to worldly passion.

**8.** In the details of the drama the biographies differ slightly: according to one, the Lord wrote the letter with His finger, according to another, with His toes; according to one, He sat on a couch, according to another, on the Deity's throne; one speaks of the effulgence for “seven days,” another for “seven days and nights”; according to one, the Lord gave everyone the power to honour each energy, according to another, He taught them this respect.

**9.** Mahamaya here is not the external energy that covers living beings: the Lord is not subject to maya. In the “Charitamrita” (Adi 17.242) this form is called Yogamaya — the Lord's internal energy, which serves His pastimes.

**10.** The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 18.225) explains that in this way, dancing in the mood of the Mother, the Lord taught everyone bhakti. This is the Lord's spiritual, parental love for His devotees, beyond any worldly interpretation.

**11.** Which Deities Srila Bhaktisiddhanta installed, the biographies tell differently: according to one, Sri Guru-Gauranga and Radha-Govinda; according to another, an image of Gaura dancing in sankirtana; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 2.34) names Sri Guru-Gauranga and Gandharvika-Giridhari, and also the murtis of the acharyas of the four sampradayas. One of the biographies dates the founding of the Math to 7 March 1918, calling that day Gaura-purnima; but there was no full moon on 7 March 1918 (the full moons fell at the end of February and the end of March).

**12.** According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” the “Chaitanya-mangala” and Murari Gupta (3.3.12), it was the Lord Himself who sent Chandrashekhara to Navadvipa; according to the “Charitamrita,” it was Nityananda, already on the way to Shantipura, and first to Advaita. The biographies follow now one account, now the other, and one gives both. The original sources also differ as to who then brought Shachi to the Lord: according to the “Charitamrita,” Chandrashekhara; according to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 1), the “Chaitanya-mangala” and Murari (3.4.8–10), Nityananda.

**13.** One of the biographies says that Kala Krishnadasa was sent by Nityananda, another that the Lord sent him “with Nityananda and others.” According to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 10.67–74), Nityananda, Jagadananda, Mukunda and Damodara proposed sending him to Bengal, and the Lord permitted it; Nityananda did not go with him.